and banners carrying pictures of Pilot along with Gehlot. Pilot will also now be among the lead campaigners.

But that may not be enough, considering that the BJP has changed focus and is not targeting CM Gehlot any more. The first signs of this came at PM Modi's Udaipur rally on November 9 where he ran down the Congress government in the state, mentioning the party by name 44 times in his 41-minute speech. But he did not take Gehlot's name even once. Sources say the change has come after feedback from the ground. Former BJP CM Vasundhara Raje has apparently been saying this from the start: to avoid making the election a Modi versus Gehlot contest.



ANI

A HELPING HAND CM Gehlot with a veteran party supporter at a rally in Jaipur, Nov. 11

The party has tried to dent Gehlot's image by using the central agencies, but has failed until now to find any direct involvement of the CM in any of the scams being investigated. Corruption in the Gehlot government remains the main agenda, but the BJP has shifted focus to the Congress candidates, especially the sitting MLAs. The Congress does not seem too worried on this count, though. "Let them first find evidence of corruption by MLAs. At least Rs 10 crore worth of roads have come up in every constituency irrespective of which party represented it. Where is the corruption and where is the evidence?" asks party spokesperson Swarnim Chaturvedi.

The BJP's strength is its committed cadre along with those of the RSS, who had a big say in the distribution of tickets. Stoking Hindu religious sentiments is core to the party agenda and Modi and Shah never miss a chance to raise incidents such as the beheading of tailor Kanhaiya Lal Teli in Udaipur over the Prophet Mohammed controversy. This has forced the Congress to field bigwigs like Jairam Ramesh and P. Chidambaram to argue how local BJP leaders had facilitated the release of the accused when they were detained in another case earlier. "I wonder why the NIA (National Investigation Agency) was so quick to take over the case when we had nabbed the killers within hours," Gehlot often wonders aloud at his rallies, hinting at some complicity.

By Diwali day, the BJP was basking in pictures of the Ram temple and the celebrations at Ayodhya as greetings flowed in on social media. Suddenly, many people started talking about the BJP winning big, making Gehlot wonder if it would impact his welfare schemes narrative. In his desperation, the Congress CM has been reminding people how he has spent a lot more money on protecting cows than the previous BJP government.

The BJP has so far been ruthless in its divisive strategy. It has not given tickets to any Muslim candidate. Even a powerful leader like former minister Yunus Khan has been humiliated (he is now contesting as an independent from home constituency Deedwana in Nagaur district). But this may be because he was a key figure in organising Raje's events for the past three years, and it's well-known that the central leadership takes a dim view of anyone associated with the ex-CM. Still, Khan's influence could have helped the BJP win 3-4 seats.

In Rajasthan, the rebels of both parties have been winning 20-30 seats and cornering 14 per cent of the vote. This is crucial, as the 2018 results showed

Meanwhile, with the election just weeks away, both parties are also busy reining in the rebels. The BJP has about 30 strong rebels; the Congress has 20. In Rajasthan, rebels of both parties have been winning between 20 and 30 seats and cornering as much as 14 per cent of the vote. This is significant—the Congress formed the government in 2018 without getting a simple majority and was ahead of the BJP by just 150,000 votes.

The BJP has made only marginal changes in strategy, that is, they have not completely sidelined Raje. The former CM, is confining herself to campaigning only for those candidates who respect her publicly and seek her support. The BJP, though, is finding it difficult to answer people's queries about who, if not Raje, will be the next CM. There is little public acceptance for any other leader, but the party is not worried. "The only issue we face is whether we are winning 120 seats or 155 [of the total 200]," says Rajendra Singh Shekhawat, a senior functionary of the state BJP. This kind of confidence is missing in the Congress camp despite Gehlot's belief that he'll beat the anti-incumbency bogey this time. ■